After the Crash: 72-Hour Accident Checklist

The first 72 hours after a crash: checklist, what-not-to-say scripts for insurance calls, document organizer, claim-timeline tracker. Not legal advice.

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CHAPTER 1

Chapter 1: The First Hour After Impact: Safety, Police, and What to Record at the Scene

IMPORTANT

This checklist is practical guidance, not legal advice. For questions about fault, injury claims, or your rights, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

Step 1: Make the Scene Safe (First 5 Minutes)

- Move your vehicle out of traffic if it drives and you are not injured. Turn on hazard lights.
- If the vehicle cannot move, get yourself and passengers out and well off the roadway — behind a barrier if one exists.
- Do not stand between the two vehicles.
- Call 911 if anyone is hurt, if a lane is blocked, or if there is a hazard like a fuel leak.

Step 2: Call Police and Get the Report Started

- Ask the dispatcher for a report number before you hang up. Write it down.
- Give the responding officer your account once. Ask for the officer's name, badge number, and agency.
- Ask how to obtain the crash report and note the case number.

Step 3: Record These Facts at the Scene

Write these in your phone notes or on paper before details blur:

- Exact time, location (street names, mile marker, nearest address), and weather.

- Other driver's name, phone, license number, plate, vehicle make/model/color, and insurance company name and policy number.
- Names and phone numbers of every witness.
- Names and badge numbers of officers on scene.
- Names of any ambulance crew or hospital if someone was transported.

Step 4: Photograph Before You Leave

- Wide shots of the scene from several angles, then close-ups of damage on both vehicles.
- The other driver's plate and insurance card.
- Road conditions, skid marks, signs, and signals.

Step 5: Avoid These Statements

- Do not admit fault or guess at speed or fault. Say: "I'll give a full statement to the officer and my insurer."
- Do not discuss the crash with the other driver beyond exchanging required information.

Keep all notes and photos in one folder on your phone. You will need them for the next 72 hours.

CHAPTER 2

Chapter 2: Medical Care in the First 24 Hours: Getting Checked and Documenting Injuries

Adrenaline masks pain. Symptoms from soft-tissue injuries, whiplash, and concussions often appear hours or days after impact. Get evaluated even if you feel fine.

Getting checked

1. Call your primary care doctor or visit urgent care the same day. Emergency departments are for severe symptoms: loss of consciousness, severe headache, chest pain, numbness, or trouble moving a limb.
2. Tell the clinician you were in a motor vehicle crash and describe the mechanism (rear-ended, side impact, speed). Ask them to note it in your record.
3. Ask for a written visit summary, diagnosis codes, and work restrictions before you leave.
4. Follow every referral. Skipped appointments weaken your documentation.

Documenting injuries

- Photograph visible injuries (bruises, cuts, seatbelt marks) daily for the first week, with a date reference in frame.
- Keep a symptom log: time, what you felt, severity 1–10, what you were doing. Note headaches, stiffness, sleep problems, and difficulty concentrating. Concussion symptoms count.
- Save all paperwork: discharge instructions, prescriptions, receipts, and parking costs.

Watch for delayed symptoms

Seek care promptly for new or worsening headache, neck or back pain, dizziness, blurred vision, or memory problems. Note the date symptoms appeared—insurers scrutinize gaps between the crash and first treatment.

What to tell providers

Describe symptoms plainly. Don't minimize ("it's probably nothing") or speculate about cause beyond the crash. Don't discuss fault or insurance details with clinical staff.

Keep it consistent

Give the same account of how the crash happened to every provider. Inconsistent histories get used to question your credibility.

CHAPTER 3

Chapter 3: The 72-Hour Document Organizer: What to Collect and Where to Keep It

By hour 72, paperwork starts piling up: police report numbers, tow receipts, insurance claim numbers, and medical forms. Without one place to put them, details get lost. This chapter sets up a single document system you can run from a folder or your phone.

The master folder

Create one home for everything—a physical accordion folder or one cloud folder named with the crash date. Inside, make these subfolders:

- 01_Police: report number, officer name and badge, department phone, report copy when available.
- 02_Insurance: your policy number, claim number, adjuster name, phone, and email; the other driver's insurer details if known.
- 03_Medical: intake forms, discharge papers, receipts, and a running list of providers with dates.
- 04_Vehicle: tow company name and receipt, storage lot address, repair estimate, photos of damage.
- 05_Receipts: rental car, rideshare, parking, pharmacy, and any out-of-pocket expense.
- 06_Log: a single running timeline of who you called, when, and what they said.

What to collect in the first 72 hours

1. The police report number and the reporting officer's name.
2. Your insurance card and policy number; open the claim and write down the claim number.
3. The other driver's name, insurer, and policy number from the exchange at the scene.
4. Tow and storage receipts, with the lot's address and daily rate.

5. Every medical bill, receipt, and discharge summary.
6. Photos of damage, injuries, and the scene, backed up to the cloud.

Where to keep it

Keep the physical folder in one fixed spot—car glovebox or home desk—and photograph each paper into the cloud folder the same day. Name files with the date and type (for example, 2024-05-12_tow-receipt). Back up the cloud folder to a second account so a lost phone doesn't erase the record.

The 72-hour check

At hour 72, open the folder and confirm each subfolder has at least one item. Anything missing goes on the log as a follow-up call for Chapter 9.

CHAPTER 4

Chapter 4: What to Say and What Not to Say: Scripts for the First Insurance Call

Before You Dial

- Write down the claim number, the adjuster's name, and the date and time of the call. Keep this in your Chapter 3 organizer.
- Have your policy number, the police report number (or a note that it's pending), and the other driver's insurance details in front of you.
- Decide one goal for this call: open the claim and get the next step. Nothing more.

What to Say

Use plain, factual language. Stick to what you saw and did.

- "I'm calling to open a claim for a collision on [date] at [location]."
- "My vehicle was struck on the [front/rear/driver's side]."
- "I called police and the report number is [number]."
- "I was checked at [facility] and I'm following my doctor's instructions." (Only if true.)
- "I don't have that information in front of me. I'll call back with it."
- "Please send that request to me in writing."

What Not to Say

- Don't guess at speed, fault, or injuries. "I'm not sure" is a complete answer.
- Don't say "I'm fine" or "it was nothing." You may not know the extent of injuries yet.

- Don't accept a settlement or give a recorded statement on this first call. Ask for the request in writing and time to review.
- Don't speculate about the other driver's actions beyond what you observed.
- Don't apologize or accept blame. Describe events, don't assign fault.

Close the Call

Ask three questions and write the answers down:

1. What is my claim number?
2. What is the next step, and who does it?
3. When should I expect to hear back?

Note the adjuster's direct number and confirm any promises by email.

CHAPTER 5

Chapter 5: How to Report the Crash: Police Reports, Your Insurer, and the Other Driver's Insurer

Three reports matter in the first 72 hours: the police report, your own insurer's first notice of loss, and the claim you open with the other driver's insurer. Do them in that order.

Step 1: Get the police report number

- At the scene, ask the officer for the report number and the department name before they leave. If no officer responded, call the non-emergency line and ask whether a report will be taken.
- Within 24–72 hours, request a copy. Many departments offer online portals; otherwise ask for the records unit and the fee. Note the report number in your organizer.
- Read it when it arrives. Check that your statement, the other driver's information, and the damage description are accurate. Errors are corrected through the department's records process, so ask the records unit what their procedure is.

Step 2: Report to your own insurer

- Call the claims line, not your agent's office, unless your policy says otherwise. Open a claim even if you believe the other driver is at fault; your policy may cover a rental or medical payments regardless of fault.
- Give the facts from your Chapter 4 script: date, time, location, vehicles, injuries, police report number. Do not guess at fault or speculate about speed.
- Ask three questions and write down the answers: Is a rental covered and for how many days? Is there a medical payments benefit? What is my deductible and will you pursue the other insurer for it?

Step 3: Report to the other driver's insurer

- Call only after you have their policy number from the police report or the exchange at the scene. If you can't find it, your insurer can request it.
- Give your statement once. Ask for the claim number and the adjuster's name, direct line, and email. Confirm in writing (email) what you said by phone.
- Expect a recorded statement request. You can decline and offer a written statement instead; nothing requires you to give a recorded statement in the first 72 hours.

Checklist before you hang up

- Claim number and adjuster contact for each insurer
- Police report number and how to obtain the copy
- Rental and medical coverage answers in writing
- One email per insurer summarizing the call

CHAPTER 6

Chapter 6: Photographs, Witnesses, and Evidence: A Capture Checklist Before Details Fade

Memories drift within days: people misremember positions, and skid marks wash away. Capture these items now, then stop.

Photographs (Do This Today, Not Next Week)

- Shoot wide, then close. For each subject, take one wide shot showing the scene and one close-up showing detail.
- Vehicle damage: all four corners, plus the point of impact from two angles. Include the license plates of both vehicles.
- The scene: road layout, lane markings, signs, traffic signals, and the position of the vehicles before they were moved (use your first-hour notes if cars were already cleared).
- Conditions: weather, lighting, and road surface. Include a shot with a time reference, such as a clock or phone screen.
- Injuries: photograph visible bruising or cuts on day one and again on days three and seven. Bruising often appears later, and a dated photo trail shows progression.
- Documents: photograph the other driver's license, insurance card, and registration at the scene if you can do so safely. Otherwise, photograph the copies you were given.

Witnesses

- Record full names, phone numbers, and email addresses. A name alone is useless if you can't reach the person.
- Note each witness's vantage point in one line, for example: "stood on corner, saw the other car run the

light."

- Ask whether they will give a written statement. If yes, get it in their own words with a date and signature.
- Contact each witness within 48 hours to confirm they're willing to talk to an insurer. Witnesses go quiet fast.

Evidence Preservation

- Save dashcam or phone footage to two locations before it overwrites.
- Check nearby businesses for security cameras and ask the manager to preserve footage. Get the manager's name and the camera's location.
- Keep damaged parts and torn clothing. Don't repair or clean the vehicle before an adjuster inspects it.
- Store everything in one folder, digital and physical, labeled by date.

Once this checklist is done, stop collecting and move to your claim.

CHAPTER 7

Chapter 7: Your Vehicle: Towing, Storage, Repair Estimates, and the Total-Loss Decision

Get the Vehicle to a Documented Location

1. Ask the tow driver for the company name, phone number, and the exact address where the car is going. Write it down before the truck leaves.
2. Tell the driver where to take it: a repair shop you choose, or a storage lot. If you don't specify, police-arranged tows often go to a rotation lot that charges daily fees.
3. Photograph the car at the tow lot before it moves again. Note the odometer reading.

Storage Fees Are Your Clock

Storage can run per-day charges that add up fast. Call your insurer the same day and ask two questions: will they pay storage, and for how many days? Get the answer and the agent's name in writing (email or text). If the insurer won't cover storage, move the car to a free location or your chosen shop quickly.

Reading a Repair Estimate

- Ask for the estimate in writing, itemized by part and labor.
- Check whether it includes "supplement" language — hidden damage found after disassembly is common.
- Get a second estimate if the first seems low or vague.
- Keep every estimate; you'll need them for the claim file.

The Total-Loss Decision

A car is typically declared a total loss when repair costs approach or exceed its actual cash value (ACV). If you get a total-loss notice:

1. Request the valuation report showing comparables (similar cars, mileage, condition).
2. Check the comparables yourself — same year, trim, and mileage in your region.
3. If the offer is low, submit your own evidence: recent maintenance records, new tires, low mileage.
4. Decide: accept the offer and sign the title over, or negotiate before signing. Don't sign the settlement release until you've reviewed the valuation.

Keep a one-page log: tow company, lot address, daily storage rate, estimate dates, and every insurer contact with date and name.

CHAPTER 8

Chapter 8: Rental Cars, Medical Bills, and Out-of-Pocket Costs: Tracking What You're Owed

Three expense streams run in parallel after a crash: rental or replacement transportation, medical bills, and small out-of-pocket costs. Each is reimbursed through a different process, so track them separately.

Rental and Replacement Transportation

1. Ask your insurer whether your policy includes rental reimbursement and what the daily cap is. Write down the answer and the date you asked.
2. If the other driver was at fault, their insurer may pay for a rental directly. Ask for a claim number and a direct-billing authorization before you pick up the car.
3. Keep the rental agreement, every receipt, and the return inspection sheet. If you pay out of pocket, submit receipts with a written request for reimbursement.
4. If no rental is authorized, log alternative costs (rideshare, bus fare, borrowed-car fuel) with dates and amounts.

Medical Bills

- Request an itemized bill from every provider, not just a balance-due notice.
- Keep explanation-of-benefits statements from your health insurer next to each bill.
- Track mileage to appointments and any parking fees; these are commonly reimbursable.
- Note dates of missed work and lost wages separately, with employer confirmation if possible.

The Out-of-Pocket Ledger

Create one page with columns: date, expense, amount, receipt saved (yes/no), who was told, and reimbursement status. Log every expense the same day. At the 72-hour mark, total what you've paid and send a written summary to the adjuster handling your claim, asking for confirmation of what will be reimbursed and when.

CHAPTER 9

Chapter 9: The Claim Timeline Tracker: Deadlines, Follow-Ups, and a 72-Hour Log

A claim stalls when no one is watching the clock. Your job is to be the person who watches it.

Build the tracker

Create a single spreadsheet or paper grid with these columns:

- Date and time
- Who you contacted (name, company, phone extension)
- Method (call, email, portal upload)
- What you asked for or sent
- What they promised, and by when
- Follow-up date
- Status (open, waiting, resolved)

Log every contact the same day it happens. A claim adjuster handling dozens of files will not remember your call; your notes are the record.

Deadlines to mark on a calendar

- Your policy's notice window. Most auto policies require prompt notice of an accident. Check your declarations page for the exact language and note the date you reported.
- State statute of limitations. This is the deadline to file a lawsuit if the claim stalls. It varies by state and claim type. Look up your state's limit for personal injury and property damage, or ask your insurer to confirm it in writing, and record both dates.

- Response windows. Note when you sent each document and when a reply is due. If nothing arrives, follow up in writing rather than by phone.

The 72-hour log

For the first three days, add a short entry every evening: what happened, who you spoke to, what you submitted, and what you're waiting on. Include medical appointments and any symptom changes. This log becomes the backbone of your tracker and a clean factual record if the claim is later disputed.

Follow-up rhythm

- Day 3: confirm your insurer received the police report number and your documents.
- Day 7: ask the adjuster for a claim number and the next step in writing.
- Every 7–10 days after that: one written follow-up per open item. Keep it to two sentences: what you sent, what you need, and the date you expect it.

If a promised callback doesn't happen, log the miss and send an email referencing the promise and its date.

CHAPTER 10

Chapter 10: When to Stop Handling It Alone: Red Flags That Call for a Lawyer or Formal Complaint

Most claims close without a lawyer. Your job is to recognize the cases that shouldn't be handled alone, and to act on the signals early rather than after a deadline passes.

Red flags that call for a lawyer

- Injury with lasting effects. Ongoing treatment, a recommended surgery, or symptoms that haven't resolved weeks after the crash.
- A disputed liability claim. The other driver or insurer says you caused or shared fault, or the police report conflicts with the other party's account.
- A lowball or "final" offer. An adjuster pressures you to sign a release before you know your full medical costs.
- A recorded statement request you've already given, or repeated requests to give one after you've declined.
- An uninsured or underinsured driver, or a hit-and-run with no identified party.
- A commercial vehicle (truck, delivery van, rideshare) — corporate insurers and multiple policies change the math.
- A minor involved, or a crash involving a fatality.
- Deadlines approaching you can't meet — statute of limitations, claim filing windows, or a repair/storage bill you can't resolve.
- Bad-faith conduct. Missed response deadlines, contradictory statements, or refusal to provide the policy limits in writing.

How to escalate a formal complaint

If the problem is the insurer's conduct rather than the crash itself, file a complaint with your state's department of insurance. Include your policy number, claim number, a dated timeline of contacts, and copies of written correspondence. Keep the originals.

Decision rule

When two or more red flags apply, or any single flag involves injury or disputed fault, get a consultation. Most personal injury lawyers offer free initial consultations and work on contingency, so the call costs you nothing but time. Bring your Chapter 3 document organizer and Chapter 9 timeline to that meeting.